

The Journal

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FRONT PAGE

Report from Jerusalem: As Israel Keeps Bombing Iran, Palestinians Face Growing Violence in West Bank

Democracy Now!

Democracy Now! speaks with Iranian Israeli political activist Orly Noy about her recent piece, “Longing for My Tehran.” “It’s been a very emotional time since the beginning of the war, not just because we are constantly running in and out of shelters,” says Noy, “but because this time, the footage of the bombing that I grew accustomed to seeing for over two years from the genocide in Gaza was now coming from my homeland.”

Noy also comments on Israeli political support for the war on Iran, saying “the very few attempts to protest against the war were brutally crushed by the Israeli police.” Israeli violence against Palestinians in the West Bank is also increasing. “Up until now, our worry was about the ethnic cleansing of the West Bank. Now it is just about executing Palestinians, both by the army and by the settlers,” says Noy.

FEATURES

This Sunshine Week, Florida reflects an alarming national trend of blocking the public's access to information

David Cuillier, Director of the Brechner Freedom of Information Project, College of Journalism and Communications, University of Florida · The Conversation (Politics)

By all measures, the ability to see what the government is up to in the United States has plummeted to new depths since the beginning of the second Trump administration.

For National Sunshine Week in 2025, I wrote about secrecy creep , the adoption of federal secrecy protections implemented by state and local authorities. In Florida and throughout the United States, this threatens the public's right to be informed about its government.

A year later, this creep toward secrecy has become an all-out slide.

As director of the Joseph L. Brechner Freedom of Information Project at the University of Florida, I track the state of government transparency in the U. S. What has changed since January 2025 is unprecedented.

Clouds in the Sunshine State

Florida is a good example of this slide. Once viewed as a leader in transparency , the Sunshine State now charges exorbitant copy fees that discourage average people from requesting public records .

According to the nonprofit MuckRock, 24% of public records requests in Florida come with a copy fee , averaging US\$1,623. Only Oregon charges fees more often, at 28% of the time. Fees are intended to help agencies cover the cost of large requests, but they tend to be arbitrary and are often used as a way to get pesky people to go away.

And that's assuming you even get the information you want. One of my own studies from 2019 indicated that, on average, if you requested a public record in Florida, you would receive it about 39% of the time , placing the state 31st in the nation.

In 2025, MuckRock put the percentage dipping lower, at 35% . In March 2026, it was at 34% .

In Florida, more and more government agencies are thwarting the public's right to know, including attempts to hide the details behind Alligator Alcatraz , the temporary immigrant detention center built in the Florida Everglades in June 2025. The state's Department of Government Efficiency, or DOGE, office has pushed cities to be more transparent while withholding its own records .

Members of the state Legislature are attempting to strengthen the public records law . This would improve transparency in Florida's state government, but I'd argue it doesn't go far enough. Other states, such as Ohio, Pennsylvania and Connecticut, have implemented stronger laws, including independent enforcement of their sunshine laws , to ensure their governments comply.

It starts at the top

State and local governments appear to be taking their cues from the federal government.

President Donald Trump's administration heralds itself as the most transparent in history , pointing to the president's willingness to talk informally to the press or directly to the public through social media.

While that may be one definition of transparency, the federal government's willingness to provide documents that show what the government is doing – not just what it says it is doing – has been eviscerated under the second Trump administration. Examples include:

This led some agencies, such as the Department of Energy, to apply unorthodox practices, including closing out pending requests.

David Cuillier, Director of the Brechner Freedom of Information Project, College of Journalism and Communications, University of Florida

Refusing to provide tax returns , again, unlike every other president in modern history, and then suing the IRS for \$10 billion when some returns were leaked.

Removing government websites and databases .

Firing the national archivist and the director of the Office of Information Policy , the agency within the U. S. Department of Justice that oversees government agencies' compliance with requests under the Freedom of Information Act , or FOIA.

Firing and pushing out experienced staffers assigned to handle FOIA requests as part of the 2025 U. S. DOGE purges . This led some agencies, such as the Department of Energy, to apply unorthodox practices, including closing out pending requests .

Axing the new Open Government Federal Advisory Committee , which was launched to find ways of improving FOIA.

Pulling out of the Open Government Partnership , which the U. S. helped found in 2011 to foster transparency around the globe.

As the federal government has taken steps to become less transparent, many state and local governments have followed. Anadolu/Anadolu via Getty Images

Typically, the Department of Justice releases annual statistics on FOIA requests every March. When I examined initial reports posted in January, when just 11 agencies had provided their reports, backlogs – that is, requests that remain

Pete Hegseth is working hard to make sure the public hears only good news about Iran war

Kathy Kiely, Professor and Lee Hills Chair of Free Press Studies, University of Missouri-Columbia · The Conversation (Politics)

The Trump administration doesn't like the free press's coverage of the Iran war. MirageC/Getty

Martha Gellhorn stowed away on a hospital ship to become the only woman journalist to land on Normandy Beach on D-Day. She carried stretchers before writing her harrowing account of the invasion.

The New Yorker's famously epicurean writer A. J. Liebling subsisted on military rations and came under fire during World War II to describe what it was like for the soldiers and sailors at war.

Syndicated columnist Ernie Pyle died, in a helmet and Army fatigues, among some of the troops whose names and hometowns he carefully included in his dispatches. "At this spot, the 77th Infantry lost a buddy," read the makeshift sign posted at the place where a Japanese machine gun bullet felled him.

Those reporters told stories of war in all its gore and its glory, its exhilaration and its ennui. Others have laid bare the anxiety and doubts.

Veteran Vietnam correspondent Neil Sheehan broke the story of the Pentagon Papers, which showed how government officials deceived the public about the Vietnam war. Sheehan won a Pulitzer Prize for his book, "A Bright Shining Lie," which chronicled the war's impact on idealists who once believed in it, through the story of his relationship with an inside source.

Well before bombs started dropping on Iran and President Donald Trump began to tease the notion of a ground invasion, his defense secretary, Pete Hegseth, began putting obstacles in the way of the reporters with the most experience covering the nation's military. While Hegseth's moves haven't stopped the reporters from doing their jobs, it has made it harder for them to keep the public informed.

As someone who worked as a Washington correspondent for decades, I worry that these obstacles could limit the number of reporters who have the experience with – and trust of – key sources to do the kind of in-depth, nuanced journalism that a war, with its price in lives and resources, deserves.

A group of press correspondents on board a U. S. landing craft en route to amphibious maneuvers off the coast of England on May 8, 1944, including, with his back to the camera on right, A. J. Liebling of The New Yorker magazine. AP photo

Corralling the watchdogs

Generally, war correspondents need the cooperation of the military they are covering to get to the front. For the U.

S. press, that requires relationships and credibility at the Pentagon.

Early in 2025, Hegseth ordered major news organizations to give up their desks in the Pentagon press room to MAGA favorites. NPR's desk went to Breitbart News. Roaming the hallways, where reporters sometimes found sources who would deviate from the company line, became verboten.

Eventually, the area in the Pentagon where reporters were allowed was circumscribed to a single corridor outside the press room – even though the public affairs officers who worked most closely with reporters were in an office on the other side of the 6½-million-square-foot building.

Then Hegseth conditioned the issuance of press credentials on reporters, effectively giving military brass the right to censor or sanitize their reports.

As a result, almost the entire Pentagon press corps, which included outlets ranging from The Associated Press to The New York Times to Fox News and USNI News, which covers the Navy, moved out of the building in October 2025. Some have been invited back for the press briefings Hegseth and Gen. Dan Caine, chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff, have begun to give on progress of the battle in Iran.

But after the first of these briefings, the Pentagon abruptly banned photographers from attending, reportedly because Hegseth's staff found some of their images of him to be unflattering.

Secretary on defense

Gone are the off-camera "background" briefings where Department of Defense brass could give trusted reporters greater context and nuance for battlefield decisions. Gone are the impromptu hallway meetings where reporters have, with luck or persistence, picked up information that deviates from an administration's agreed-upon script.

Also not in evidence, at least not so far: the deployment of the kind of journalistic embed program that the Pentagon used during the Iraq war to give the American people an up-close look at troops in the conflict zone.

How might that affect what you, the public, gets to know? It was a combination of an anonymous tip and insider access that led the legendary investigative reporter Seymour Hersh to break the devastating story of My Lai, the American soldiers' massacre of civilians during the Vietnam War.

At the made-for-TV briefings he does hold, Hegseth devotes most of the session to questions from outlets such as the Epoch Times, The Daily Caller and LindellTV – owned by Mike Lindell, the head of the well-known pillow company.

At one recent briefing, one of the favored new cadre tossed Hegseth a shameless softball. Referring to American troops in the Middle East, the questioner asked: "What is your prayer for them?"

People Who Eat More Red Meat May Have Higher Risk of Type 2 Diabetes

Healthline

A recent study suggests that a higher intake of red meat may be associated with an increased risk of diabetes. Image Credit: VICUSCHKA/Getty Images

A recent study found that a person's red meat consumption may increase their risk of type 2 diabetes.

The findings also suggest that consuming alternative proteins may help reduce the risk of diabetes.

Nutrition experts offer alternative protein options to red meat to help maintain overall health.

Diabetes is a growing health concern in the United States. According to the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC), 40.1 million people had diabetes in 2023, and 115.2 million had prediabetes.

The CDC also notes that among those with diabetes, 90% to 95% have type 2 diabetes.

Type 2 diabetes can generally be prevented or delayed with lifestyle changes, such as diet, exercise, and weight management.

A recent study published in the British Journal of Nutrition found that higher red meat intake was associated with a higher risk of diabetes.

It also found that substituting red meat for other protein sources may help lower a person's risk of developing diabetes.

"This study adds to a consistent body of research showing that higher red meat intake is linked with higher rates of type 2 diabetes," said Michelle Routhenstein, a preventive cardiology dietitian at Entirely Nourished, who was not involved in the study.

"In this large NHANES analysis, those eating the most red meat had about 49% higher odds of having diabetes compared to those eating the least. When we see similar findings across different types of research, it strengthens the overall message," Routhenstein told Healthline.

Higher red meat intake and diabetes risk

In this population-based cross-sectional study, the researchers analyzed data from the National Health and Nutrition Examination Survey (NHANES) from 2003 to 2016.

They defined having diabetes as "being diagnosed by a physician or other health professional, having a fasting plasma glucose of 126 mg/dL or higher, an HbA1c level of 6.5% or higher, or the use of antidiabetic drugs."

The study included 34,737 participants with an average age of 45.8. Among these, 10.5% had diabetes. Those who had

the highest intake of total red meat consumed an average of 5.72 ounces per day.

After the researchers adjusted for demographics, lifestyle, socioeconomic status, and other dietary habits, they found that higher red meat consumption was associated with increased diabetes risk.

However, it is important to note that association does not establish a causal relationship. "While this type of study cannot prove cause and effect, the results closely align with long-term prospective studies that show a clear dose-response relationship, especially for processed red meat," Routhenstein said.

After repeated analyses, the researchers found that each additional serving of total red meat per day was associated with a 16% increased risk of diabetes. They also found that each serving of processed or unprocessed red meat gave a 10% higher risk of diabetes.

"Red meat is generally defined to include beef, veal, pork, lamb, and game meat," said David Cutler, MD, board certified family medicine physician at Providence Saint John's Health Center in Santa Monica, CA, who was not involved in the study.

"There are longstanding recommendations from nutrition and diabetes experts to limit red meat by consuming it only in low frequency and small amounts, choosing leaner cuts and avoiding processed meats, like bacon, ham, and sausages, altogether. I suggest no more than two servings of red meat per week, with a serving [being] about the size of your fist, 4 to 6 ounces," Cutler told Healthline.

Routhenstein elaborated by recommending no more than 1 serving per week of red meat.

"If eliminating it right away feels overwhelming, a helpful first step is transitioning to leaner cuts such as sirloin, tenderloin, or 90–95% lean ground beef," she said. "The goal is not total avoidance, but shifting red meat from a daily habit to an occasional choice."

Red meat substitutions may lower diabetes risk by up to 14%

The study analyzed how substituting red meat for other proteins may affect a person's risk of diabetes.

They found that participants who replaced one serving of red meat per day with plant-based protein sources, such as legumes, nuts or seeds, or soy products, showed a 14% reduced risk of diabetes.

Participants who substituted dairy, poultry, or whole grains for red meat saw an 11% to 12% reduction in diabetes risk.

This suggests that replacing red meat with plant-based proteins may be associated with a lower risk of diabetes.

However, causality has yet to be established.

Meta & Google Found Liable in Landmark Cases for Knowingly Causing Harm to Young People

Democracy Now!

Juries in California and New Mexico have found the tech giants Alphabet and Meta liable for knowingly causing harm to children and teens who used their social media platforms. Over the course of the trials, documents revealed that tech companies were well aware of the addictive properties of their social media products and exploited these properties to increase their profits. “They take advantage of the undeveloped frontal cortex of young people and their emotional need for validation by showing them things, not that they want to see, but what they can’t look away from,” says attorney Matthew P. Bergman, who represented the plaintiffs in the California case.

Youth advocate Zamaan Qureshi, who testified in the New Mexico case against Meta, says the verdicts indicate that “Meta’s house of cards is falling, and it is absolutely clear that they will be held accountable.”

Headlines for March 27, 2026

Democracy Now!

Trump Again Delays Ultimatum for Iran to Open Strait of Hormuz

Pentagon Considering Ground Invasion as Part of “Final Blow” Against Iran

Oil Prices Soar as Iran’s Military Declares Strait of Hormuz “Closed” to U.S.-Aligned Ships

Missile and Drone Attacks from Iran and Hezbollah Leave One Israeli Dead, 25 Wounded

Israel Expands Invasion of Southern Lebanon as UNICEF Warns Attacks Have Killed 121 Children

House Democratic Leaders Delay Vote on Iran War Powers Resolution Until at Least Mid-April

Mexican Navy Searches for Two Ships Missing from Cuba-Bound Aid Flotilla

Nicolás Maduro and Cilia Flores Appear in Federal Court, Months After Abduction by U.S. Forces

Senate Votes to Fund Most of DHS After Partial Government Shutdown Leads to Airport Chaos

Federal Court Blocks Pentagon’s Blacklisting of Anthropic over AI Safety Guardrails

Oil Trading Surged Minutes Before Trump Claimed “Productive” Talks with Iran

Russian Oil Exports Fall Dramatically After Ukraine Attacks Baltic Sea Oil Terminals

IOC Bans Transgender Women from Women’s Events at 2028 Summer Olympics

NYU Professors Win Big Raises as Part of Tentative Deal to End Strike

IN BRIEF

Mirit Eyal-Cohen and Jay A. Soled, opinion contributor, The Hill (general): The tax code should make clear that activities fused with fun, excitement and personal enjoyment are never an occasion for a tax deduction.

Sarah Davis, The Hill (general): Reza Pahlavi, the exiled crown prince of Iran, said freedom in Iran is “within reach” in a speech at the Conservative Political Action Conference (CPAC) on Saturday. “A free Iran is not a fantasy,” Pahlavi said. “A free Iran is within reach right now, but as we all know, freedom never comes free.” The son...

Jules Yap, IKEA Hackers: A new IKEA study has confirmed what many of us have suspected while staring into cluttered cabinets: our kitchens just aren’t working for us. The good news? You don’t need a full renovation to turn things around. According to the IKEA Cooking & Eating Report 2026, one of the largest studies of its kind, surveying over 31,000 people across 31 countries, fewer than one in three of us are actually happy with our kitchens. And the number one culprit? Space. [...]

Douglas MacKinnon, opinion contributor, The Hill (general): President Trump’s instinct now is to fight for his country. But to do so, he needs to hear the good, the bad, and the ugly surrounding every policy or potential military operation.

Sarah Davis, The Hill (general): Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi pledged his country will “exact HEAVY price” after he said the Israeli military violated the Trump administration’s pause on strikes against Iranian energy infrastructure. “Israel has hit 2 of Iran’s largest steel factories, a power plant and civilian nuclear sites among other infrastructure. Israel claims it acted in coordination with...

Jeffrey Blehar, National Review: Demonstrators gather in front of law enforcement officers during a protest at Immigration and Customs Enforcement headquarters in Portland, Ore., October 4, 2025.

Angela Giuffrida in Rome, The Guardian: Prime minister is scrambling to clean up her government after youth vote powered a damaging referendum defeat

Filippo Micheleni was having a drink at San Calisto, a popular bar in Rome’s Trastevere neighbourhood on Wednesday night. As he chatted to his friends, Giorgia Meloni’s far-right government was reeling from a failed referendum, and her beleaguered tourism minister, Daniela Santanchè, had just resigned.

Micheleni, a 29-year-old computer scientist who lives in Brussels, was spending a few days in the Italian capital after returning home last weekend to cast his ballot in the referendum. He had been in Rome for a few days, but he had not yet decided whether to vote.

Ground Invasion of Iran Could Be “Suicide Mission” for U.S.: Ex-Army Intelligence Analyst

Democracy Now!

We get an analysis of the Trump administration’s Iran war strategy from former U. S. Army intelligence analyst Harrison Mann. “From day two of this war, the Trump administration has not known what to do and how to get out of this,” says Mann, who resigned from the U. S. Army’s Defense Intelligence Agency in 2024 over the Biden administration’s policy in Gaza. As Trump is rumored to be eyeing the oil export hub of Kharg Island for seizure, Mann gives his assessment of a potential ground invasion of Iran. “Any attempt to seize this island would be close to a suicide mission,” he says. While U. S. leaders struggle to respond to Iran’s blockade of the Strait of Hormuz and attacks on military bases in U. S.-allied Gulf states, Mann notes that “the people who drove [Trump] into this war pretty much expected this.

I don’t think this is a surprise to Lindsey Graham and Marco Rubio or Benjamin Netanyahu — who is very much getting what he wanted, which is dragging the U. S. into what he hopes will be a decisive war of annihilation against Iran.”

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